Chinese had come during the British colonial era and most of them lived in Kolkata, where they worked as tanners, shoemakers, and carpenters, and owned restaurants, beauty parlours, shops, and other small businesses. If they had any political sympathies, it would be with the Nationalist Chinese government in Taiwan rather than the Communists in Beijing. The Overseas Chinese Association in Kolkata openly expressed support for the Indian government throughout the conflict and even urged it not to accept Beijing's 'dirty offer' of a ceasefire in November.[19]

Nevertheless, the Foreigners (Restriction of Chinese Nationals) Order, which was issued on 25 October, prohibited any person of Chinese descent from leaving his or her village for longer than 24 hours without written permission from local officials. Five days later, another order was issued making it possible to detain 'any person not of Indian origin who was at birth a citizen or subject of any country at war with, or committing external aggression against, India'.[20]

Then came the promulgation of the Foreigners (Internment) Order of 3 November under which the authorities in Assam and certain districts of northern West Bengal arrested all residents of Chinese descent and transported them over 1,500 kilometres away to an internment camp at Deoli in Rajasthan. By February 1963, according to the government's account, there were 2,165 ethnic Chinese at Deoli and an additional 143 detained in local jails.[21] Almost all of them had come from the northeastern border regions.

One of those interned was Yin Marsh, who was born in Kolkata and raised in Darjeeling, where her family ran a popular Chinese restaurant. She, her father, grandmother, and eight-year-old brother were all sent to Deoli, a harrowing experience which she has related in her book *Doing Time with Nehru: The Story of an Indian-Chinese Family*. The title alludes to the ironic coincidence that Nehru, who had authorized the mass arrests, had once been detained in Deoli by the British during India's struggle for independence.[22]

In the end, none of the detainees in Deoli, or any other Indian person of Chinese descent, was brought to trial for espionage or other charges.[23] But in 1963, 2,395 ethnic Chinese, of whom 1,665 were internees and 730 their dependents, were repatriated to China. For those who remained, the situation became untenable, and between 1962 and 1967 another 7,500 left